So, that is when I break the news to my parents, my friends, a few teammates. I explain what's happened and that I have since gone back to ask whether I could play a Test at Old Trafford one last time, maybe play a few games through the summer and then happily go with everything achieved, and the powers that be have told me no. It's one Test or nothing. All those wickets. All that drama. All that pain. All that time, and this is how I'm telling the people closest to me; on my own, overlooking the car park in the lunch room at Trent Bridge. I call them, staring out at the bland, stacked nothingness of parked cars. I frame it in a way that sounds like I am comfortable about it. Underneath, something is rattling me about the way this is all going down. I'm behaving more at peace with it than I actually am to protect them, to dial down the volume of the injustice they might feel on my behalf. My dad sounds like he's taking a call for which he has been preparing himself for years. My mum is more emotional. I'm going to stay on with the coaching team, I say, but Lord's is the last Test and the news will be out at 5pm. I don't know how the papers got the information, I say when they inevitably ask. I'm not sure where the leak came from. As we talk, I realise how angry I am about not being able to do this in person with people who have travelled with me on this journey, that a fundamental courtesy has been overlooked. I couldn't tell most of the people I wanted to know about the news in time – there's not enough room in the afternoon to contact people as I semi-manically scroll up and down my contacts trying to think who needs to know. Then I give up. They will find out through the article and their phones at 5pm. It doesn't feel right, to be sitting here, out of control of anything, just waiting.

As the news breaks, I just sit there, watching it all become real. My phone is an endless newsreel of my own career ending. That evening, I am a few Guinness deep, speaking to friends, processing the unprocessable. I think of Greg James and *Tailenders*. Our show has been an escape from the seriousness of cricket for the last six or seven years, but maybe my first response could be in the safest place possible to me, where I know I will get the time and space to say it how I need to. I'm going to need some sort of statement too. An international career that has lasted 19 years, and I have not once planned what a retirement statement might look like. I text Greg, 'would you be able to help with what I write in the post?'. 'Of course,' he says. I write out a short and sharp example for him, paraphrasing what I am